2016). It also performed very strongly in the elections for the State and Region legislatures, with the striking exceptions of the Rakhine and Shan States.

In Rakhine State, Myanmar's reforms have yet to have much positive impact, mostly because of ongoing tension between Muslim and Buddhist communities. In 2012, a wave of violence across northern Rakhine State saw 140,000 people, the majority of them Muslims, displaced from their homes. Many villages and neighbourhoods were burned to the ground in this anti-Muslim pogrom. Retaliatory attacks on Buddhist villages tore at the fabric of multi-religious local life, with unreconciled claims of indigeneity providing fuel for the communal antagonism (Thawnghmung 2016a). After the smoke had cleared, Myanmar was faced with an emboldened Buddhist chauvinist movement seeking to stamp its values on the national story. Politicians retreated in the face of support for these bigoted politics, which were made famous by the sermons of monks around the country (Walton and Hayward 2014). Wirathu, a preacher from Mandalay, became the most outspoken advocate for the nationalist cause, cloaking himself in ideas about the defence of race and religion. In the lead-up to the 2015 vote, people wondered about the potential influence of nationalist rhetoric on the election outcome. As it happened, the nationalist anti-NLD mobilisation failed to sway enough voters to influence the final result.

With its post-election majority in the Union Assembly, the NLD's Htin Kyaw, one of Aung San Suu Kyi's close confidants, was elevated to the presidency while Henry Van Thio, an ethnic Chin, became vice-president. The military's nominee for vice-president, Myint Swe, a retired general who previously served as chief minister of Yangon Region, took the other senior post. Htin Kyaw's cabinet also blends elements of the old and the new, seeking to strike a balance between experience, technical competence, and democratic orientation. The difficulty for the NLD is that so few of its senior figures have any substantial experience of government decision-making. And now that they have a greater say in national affairs there are difficulties aplenty. For a start, the separation between the military and the government has the potential to introduce tension at the heart of the Naypyitaw decision-making apparatus. There are few obvious mechanisms apart from trust building and personal connections that will avoid future showdowns between alienated elements of the NLD and military.

As Myanmar's political system continues to evolve, *Conflict in Myanmar* takes the time to consider conflict in its military, political and religious dimensions. The story of these enduring problems needs extra attention at